FIND YOUR SQUARE

The Thirty-Six Squares

Find your square. It tells you what to buy next.

MARK YOUR SQUARE

Design capability down the left, AI adoption across the top. Six levels each, thirty-six combinations, and your organization sits in one of them. The square does not tell you whether you need design. It tells you what **form** design should take right now, which is the part that decides whether the money works.

Capability is numbered 1 to 6 and AI is lettered A to F, as in the assessment. **Emergent with Reactive AI is 3B.**

DESIGN CAPABILITY ↑

AI ADOPTION →	A Limited	B Reactive	C Developing	D Embedded	E Leading	F Symbiotic
User-Driven 6	ADVICE	ADVICE	HIRE	BEYOND BUYING	BEYOND BUYING	BEYOND BUYING
Integrated 5	ADVICE	HIRE	HIRE	HIRE	BEYOND BUYING	BEYOND BUYING
Structured 4	CONTRACT	CONTRACT	CONTRACT	HIRE	HIRE	HIRE
Emergent 3	ADVICE	CHECK-UP	CONTRACT	CONTRACT	CONTRACT	CONTRACT
Limited 2	ADVICE	ADVICE	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP
Absent 1	ADVICE	ADVICE	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP	CHECK-UP

The orange edge marks the six squares where AI adoption has run ahead of design capability. The old failure was shipping something ugly. The new one is shipping something plausible and wrong, faster. A check-up costs less than the quarter you spend building on it.

ADVICE
An hour with someone who has seen the pattern. The cheapest thing that stops you building the wrong thing.

CHECK-UP
A read on what you already shipped. You are producing faster than you are validating.

CONTRACT
Six weeks against a named outcome. The work is known, the capacity is not.

HIRE
Full-time, on the team. Pays once there is enough recurring judgment to keep a person busy.

BEYOND BUYING
Nothing external moves the needle. You are the source now. Teach it and hire against it.

THE THIRTY-SIX SQUARES

What the levels mean

Read your own honestly, not aspirationally.

DESIGN CAPABILITY

down the left, 1 to 6

1 ABSENT
Design happens, but nobody owns it as a practice. Decisions get made on instinct and cleaned up later.

2 LIMITED
Design exists as a service. It is called in to make things presentable once the thinking is finished.

3 EMERGENT
Design is real but inconsistent. It works when a specific person pushes, and reverts when they get busy. Roughly half of all organizations sit here.

4 STRUCTURED
Design is established, with process and standards that hold. The remaining gains come from measurement and from earning decisions earlier.

5 INTEGRATED
Design is a peer function with a seat in planning and its own measures. About 4 percent of organizations reach this.

6 USER-DRIVEN
Evidence about users drives decisions across the company, not only inside design. Fewer than 1 in 2,000 report this.

AI ADOPTION

across the top, A to F

A LIMITED
AI is a personal productivity aid for admin work. No strategy, no budget, no training.

B REACTIVE
Ad hoc experimentation driven by pressure to ship something with AI in it. A lot of throwaway work.

C DEVELOPING
AI is a genuine prototyping accelerator. Adoption is problem-led and workflows are getting written down.

D EMBEDDED
AI is core infrastructure. Design scope has grown to cover trust, uncertainty, and what the system does when it should refuse.

E LEADING
Designers think natively in code and systems, and shift from producing artifacts to setting direction.

F SYMBIOTIC
Design time and runtime blur. Designers set constraints and the system assembles interfaces by context.

How to place yourself

Pick the highest level where *every* sentence is already true, not the one you are working toward. Most people overrate by one.

Score it properly

Both scales come from a fifteen-question, four-minute read at **aneilrazvi.com/map**, which hands you the square rather than your guess at it.

Then read the front

The square names the form to buy next: advice, a check-up, a contract, a hire, or nothing external at all.

LEVELS: NN/G 2021, NIELSEN 2026 · SHARES: NN/G QUIZ, N=5,371, 2022